Avoiding Common Mistakes

This section contains an overview of common rubric mistakes. Please note that for the sake of simplicity, we have kept the prompts and rubric criteria very simple for these examples – they are merely meant to serve the instructional purpose of highlighting common issues that frequently emerge as people attempt to write rubrics.

Prompt-Rubric Mismatch

- Definition
    - If prompts ask models to find specific information, that information must appear in the rubric. If a rubric contains specific information, that information must have been requested in the prompt. If these conditions are not met, this is an example of prompt-rubric mismatch.
- Example 1

Prompt	Rubric	Issue
Provide the name of every NFL team in North Carolina and the name of their stadium	Mentions the Carolina Panthers	The rubric does not mention the stadium name

- Example 2

Prompt	Rubric	Issue
Provide the name of every NFL team in North Carolina	-mentions the Carolina Panthers -mentions Bank of America Stadium	The prompt does not mention the stadium name

Asking Opinionated Questions

- Definition
    - Asking subjective, opinion-based prompts that do not have one clear answer.
- Example 1

Prompt	Rubric	Issue
Why was Company X's 2024 billboard campaign successful?	States that Company X's 2024 billboard campaign was successful because of the location of their billboards.	Different experts could point to other factors like a witty catchphrase or eye-popping colors.

Rubrics that are not Self-Contained

- Definition
    - Creating rubrics in the abstract that do not contain all necessary information to evaluate rubric accuracy.
- Example 1

Prompt	Rubric	Issue
Use 2024 Q1, Q2, Q3, and Q4 sales to calculate 2024 revenue for Company X	Calculates 2024 revenue by adding 2024 Q1, Q2, Q3, and Q4 sales together	The rubric does not provide an objective answer for the company's revenue, meaning that correctly adding incorrect revenues would satisfy this rubric

- Example 2

Prompt	Rubric	Issue
Provide a list of all restaurants within 1 mile of 123 Main Street, San Francisco, California	Mentions all restaurants within 1 mile of 123 Main Street, San Francisco, California	The rubric does not explicitly list all restaurants within 1 mile of 123 Main Street, so the model's answer cannot be accurately evaluated

Stacking Multiple Criteria into 1 Rubric

- Definition
    - Eliminating the possibility of partial credit by combining multiple responses into one rubric section

Prompt	Rubric	Issue
Provide a list of all restaurants within 1 mile of 123 Main Street, San Francisco, California	Mentions Restaurant X, Diner Y, and Bistro Z	Even if the model correctly identified 2/3 restaurants, the rubric would award 0 points. Instead, each restaurant should award 5 points

Unsubstantiated Rubrics

- Definition
    - Each rubric component should include a link to a source that directly states the desired information
- Example Rubric

    - [+5] Mentions that Company X's 2024 revenue is $1M
- Example Source Quote
    - Quote: "24Q1 Revenue $250k" (Found on PDF page 22)
    - Justification: Since the revenue for 24Q1 was $250k, multiplying the single quarter revenue by 4 gives $1M

Model Answers Sufficiently

- The AI model should score lower than 50% on your rubric and provide an answer that would be generally seen as unacceptable to count as a reasoning failure. (Note: the generally unacceptable clause aims to eliminate rubrics clearly weighted to artificially create a failure)

Numerical Rounding Tolerance

- Rubrics should include some tolerance for rounded answers. The best way to build in tolerance is providing an acceptable range for any number that could be logically rounded.

Bad Example

Prompt	Rubric	Issue
Provide the revenue for Company X in FY2022	States the revenue was $1,052,372 in FY 2022	Requires too specific of a number

Good Example

Prompt	Rubric	***Logic***
Provide the revenue for Company X in FY2022	States the revenue was between $1.05M in FY 2022 (acceptable range is $1M to $1.1M)	Provides a precise answer and logical revenue range that is not overly restrictive

Note: If you specify the source and output format in the Prompt, you do not need to include tolerances.

Avoid Methodology Requirements

Do not include criteria about calculation methodologies (e.g., "use vlookup to determine the value" or "apply filter on values great than 76,000"). Focus on evaluating final content, not the research process.

Have Verifiable Facts

Rubrics should contain verifiable facts confirmable through the provided documents.